to date other people, and now and then our paths would cross while we were out with someone else.

This had been going on for several months when I found myself booked for a speech to the Junior League Convention at the Del Coronado Hotel in San Diego. I had always looked forward to that trip down the Coast Highway: In those days before freeways, it was my favorite drive, with the blue Pacific on my right and the rolling green hills of California on my left.

I wanted to share the ride with someone and wondered who I should ask to join me. Then it suddenly occurred to me there was really only one person I wanted to share it with—Nancy Davis. I called her and she accepted and said she was a member of the Junior League in Chicago.

Pretty soon, Nancy was the only one I was calling for dates. And one night over dinner as we sat at a table for two, I said, “Let’s get married.”

She deserved a more romantic proposal than that, but—bless her—she put her hand on mine, looked into my eyes, and said, “Let’s.” Right after that, I had pictures coming up, so we had to wait two or three months before we could marry.

If the Hollywood press had gotten wind of our plans, they would have stormed the church, so, apologizing to Nancy, I suggested we have a quiet, secret wedding. She agreed and we were married in a touching ceremony in the Little Brown Church in the Valley on March 4, 1952. There were just five of us in an empty church: Nancy and me; Bill Holden, my best man; Ardis, Nancy’s matron of honor; and the minister.

After we said “I do,” Bill and Ardis took us to their house for dinner where they had a photographer who took our wedding photos. After dinner, we drove to Riverside about seventy miles southeast of Los Angeles, where we stayed overnight before driving on to Phoenix, where Nancy’s parents were vacationing.